

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Omar Ismail

Address: 95 Sandy Lane Cheam SM2 7EP

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: Dear Planning Officer,

I am writing as a local resident of Sandy Lane, Cheam, and as a father raising a young family in this neighbourhood, to formally record my strong support for planning application DM2025/01591.

I have taken the time to review all of the planning documents submitted with this application, including the Transport Statement by Caneparo Associates and the Environmental Noise Survey by Hann Tucker Associates, as well as a number of the comments submitted both for and against the proposal. Having done so, I am satisfied that this is a well-considered, policy-compliant application that will benefit the local community. I urge the London Borough of Sutton to grant planning permission.

Brownfield reuse and planning principle

The former ambulance station has stood vacant since the NHS declared it surplus to operational requirements. This modest brownfield site sits in the heart of a residential neighbourhood, and bringing it back into active, community-serving use is exactly what the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF, paragraph 124) and the London Plan encourage. The proposed development makes efficient use of previously developed land and avoids any encroachment on greenfield or protected land.

It is worth considering what this site replaces. An ambulance station operated here on a 24-hour basis, with large vehicles, sirens, reversing beepers, and crew movements at all hours of the day

and night. A calm, time-limited community and faith facility is, in practical amenity terms, a clear improvement for neighbouring residents, including those of us on Sandy Lane.

Policy compliance

Sutton Local Plan Policy 26 supports the provision and retention of community facilities, and Policy 33 recognises places of worship and community centres as essential social infrastructure. The NPPF at paragraph 97 explicitly requires planning authorities to plan positively for community facilities, including places of worship. This application is in clear and direct conformity with these policy requirements. Refusal would need to be justified against a strong policy presumption in favour of community facility provision.

Addressing a real and demonstrable local need

As a local Muslim resident raising a young family, I can speak directly to the need this facility addresses. The Muslim community in Sutton has grown substantially and existing provision is severely over-capacity. The nearest existing facilities are in Sutton town centre and Carshalton, all over two miles from the surrounding area. At present, I have to drive to reach any of them. The proposed facility at Dorset Road is a c.15 minute walk from my home. That is the difference between a facility my family can realistically use on foot or by bike and one that requires a car journey every time.

A permanent, purpose-built local facility at Dorset Road would eliminate those car journeys for my family and many others in the area, and provide an accessible base for the community. The planning statement demonstrates this need convincingly with reference to demographic data and evidence of demand.

As a parent, the community hub element of this proposal is just as important to me as the faith provision. Educational programmes, family activities, wellbeing sessions, social drop-ins, and interfaith events will be open to all residents of the Belmont Ward. Having a safe, welcoming space within walking distance where my family and our neighbours can participate in community life is something this area currently lacks. This is the kind of inclusive, locally-rooted infrastructure that makes a neighbourhood cohesive and liveable.

Design and impact on the area

The proposed works are modest. The extension is a part one, part two storey addition with a limited height increase to part of the existing building. There is no new upper floor of the kind that would generate overlooking or overshadowing concerns. The scheme includes external greening, improved access arrangements, dedicated cycle storage, and refuse stores, all of which improve the presentation and function of the site. I have no concerns about the visual impact of this development on Dorset Road or the surrounding residential streets.

Transport and parking

I have reviewed the Transport Statement and Travel Plan in detail. I am aware that some objectors have raised concerns about parking, but the submitted evidence does not support those concerns. The Transport Statement includes a parking survey conducted within a 400-metre radius of the site during a real Friday at 13:00, the peak prayer period. That survey found 269 on-street parking spaces in the surrounding area, with only 134 occupied at baseline: a utilisation rate of just 49.8%, well below the 85% parking stress threshold used by the London Borough of Sutton.

Even under the worst-case scenario modelled in the Transport Statement, adding 66 additional visitor vehicles during Friday prayer changeover, on-street utilisation would rise to only 75.5%, leaving 66 spaces still available. The Council's own parking stress threshold would not be reached unless a further 25 vehicles beyond the worst case were added. The evidence is clear: there is no material impact on residents' parking.

The modal split data reinforces this. Based on actual travel surveys of the existing BASMA congregation, 50% of Friday prayer attendees are predicted to travel on foot, only 11.7% drive alone, and 20% car-share as driver. This is a community that predominantly walks to worship. As I noted above, my own family would be among those walking or cycling rather than driving, and the application includes dedicated cycle storage to support exactly that.

I also note a point that objectors appear to have missed: the former ambulance station had 21 parking spaces (18 external and 3 internal). The development reduces on-site parking from that baseline, not increases it. The existing yellow keep-clear lines near the site access will also be removed, freeing up additional kerbside capacity for residents.

The suggestion that Friday prayers will clash with the school run at Avenue Primary Academy is factually incorrect. Friday prayer changeover runs from approximately 12:30 to 12:55. The school run peaks are 08:30 to 09:00 and 15:00 to 15:30. There is no overlap. The daily use of the facility, including classes, drop-ins, and wellbeing sessions, is small-scale and spread across the day.

Noise

The Environmental Noise Survey and Noise Impact Assessment by Hann Tucker Associates is thorough. The consultants conducted a real-world background noise survey using calibrated sound level meters, then assessed noise breakout from the building using measured sound pressure levels from the BASMA community at their current venue. This was a worst-case amplified speech scenario, not a quiet session.

The conclusion is straightforward: external noise levels at the nearest noise-sensitive receptors would not exceed the existing background noise level, even during the worst-case Friday prayer peak. The noise reaching neighbouring properties from this facility is predicted to be quieter than the existing ambient environment. This meets the Local Authority's criteria.

The report also concludes that the anticipated noise impact of the proposed use will be lower than the historic operational profile of the ambulance station, which was a 24-hour facility with sirens, engine idling, and crew movements at all hours. Operating hours for the proposed use are restricted to 07:00 to 23:00, and the planning statement does not schedule events to run routinely until that hour. The concerns raised by objectors about late-night noise are not substantiated by the acoustic evidence.

Conclusion

This proposal is good planning. It brings a brownfield site back into use, provides community infrastructure that is needed and policy-supported, delivers a sensitive design, and addresses potential impacts thoroughly. The Transport Statement demonstrates that parking capacity is more than adequate, that the school-run clash alleged by objectors does not exist, and that the modal split is overwhelmingly sustainable. The noise assessment confirms that the proposed use will be quieter than the former ambulance station and will not exceed background noise levels at neighbouring properties. As a resident and a father raising a family on Sandy Lane, I welcome this application and strongly support the grant of planning permission for DM2025/01591.

Yours faithfully,

Omar Ismail

95 Sandy Lane, Sutton, SM2 7EP